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THE 50-OVER CHAMPIONS TROPHY MARKS PAKISTAN'S FIRST GLOBAL EVENT SINCE 1996 – A MOMENT OF CELEBRATION FOR FANS AND A STERN TEST OF THE COUNTRY'S PREPAREDNESS.

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

The last time Pakistan hosted an International Cricket Council (ICC) event, the internet was virtually unheard of, social media and smartphones did not exist, and Babar Azam was just two years old. It has been that long, indeed!

When Sri Lanka captain Arjuna Ranatunga lifted the World Cup trophy to rapturous applause at Lahore's Gaddafi Stadium on March 17 1996, few could have imagined it would take Pakistan nearly 30 years to host another major cricket tournament.

While Pakistan was initially announced as a co-host for the 2011 World Cup alongside India and Sri Lanka, it was stripped of the opportunity by the ICC following the terrorist attack on the Sri Lankan team bus in Lahore in 2009. That incident had a lasting impact on cricket in the country. With international teams unwilling to travel, the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) had to make significant efforts to keep the game alive.

For more than five years, Pakistan shifted its base to the United Arab Emirates for international fixtures before gradually inviting teams back for bilateral series. Although India continues to refuse to send its team across the border, the PCB successfully hosted one leg of the 2023 Asia Cup at home, gaining some confidence from other nations.

However, the Champions Trophy will be its biggest litmus test yet.

Three years ago, when Pakistan was awarded the tournament, Ramiz Raja was chairman of the PCB. He

believes this will boost the country's confidence. "When you host a tournament after 29 years, it is a big deal. It builds your confidence and boosts the psyche of the fans and the public that there's lots to look forward to," Ramiz told *Sportstar*. "There is an air of happiness among the fans, and there's a lot to look forward to. However, it entails huge security provisions to ensure the tournament goes smoothly..."

Although Pakistan will play India at a neutral venue in Dubai, the country will host a significant portion of the tournament — including the semifinal and final (unless India qualifies for the latter) — across three venues: Lahore, Karachi, and Rawalpindi.

The PCB has faced major challenges in preparing the venues within just over 100 days, despite investing approximately PKR 12 billion in renovations. While the grounds were in reasonable shape, last-minute renovation work at Gaddafi Stadium and the National Stadium continued until the deadline, with more than 250 workers toiling day and night to complete the project.

The PCB ultimately unveiled the renovated Gaddafi Stadium during a tri-series involving Pakistan, New Zealand, and South Africa. "It was a